



Philips' DVP3356 DVD player

picture.

You can connect the DVD player to an audio system (normal) by using the audio-out jack.

Features to look for

The package of features depends on your budget. But still some features are a must for complete home entertainment.

Connections. Playability of the formats is the foremost feature of any DVD player. Since this is a complex topic, we're splitting it into three connectivity areas: picture related, sound related and additional gadget connectivity.

Picture-related connectivity. Almost all DVD players come with a standard composite-video cable to connect to the TV set. This cable can produce a decent picture, but it's also very limiting because the B&W and colour video signals are all sent together through this cable and it's easy for the colours to bleed over into other colours and lose detail and sharpness.

A DVD player with S-video cable can dramatically improve the video,

as S-video cable separates out the B&W signals from the colour signals resulting in greater clarity.

A DVD player that can use a component-video cable splits the colour signals too, allowing even greater colour range and detail.

If you have a flat-panel TV (LCD or plasma) with HDMI connectivity, buy a DVD player with HDMI connectivity for the best picture quality. This noise-free connection carries the signal digitally for the best possible transfer. HDMI is also the only con-



Samsung's BDP1600 Blu-ray player

nection that can carry the improved signal from an upconverting DVD player, and the only connection that can deliver Blu-ray's top resolution of 1080p. And since HDMI carries both picture and sound, it lets you make a simple, one-cable connection. HDMI jacks can be found on all Blu-ray players and upconverting DVD players, plus most HDTVs.

If you have a television with progressive-scan capability (a 100Hz television may have it), a progressive-scan-capable DVD player will give you a picture that is virtually flicker-free.

Sound related connectivity. Go for a DVD player with multi-channel surround sound if you have the right equipment to enjoy it or plan to buy one.

Typically, a multi-channel DVD

player comes with 5.1 connectivity (six pins) for audio alone: Front left, front right, rear left, rear right, centre and sub-woofer. As most televisions can take only two connections for audio (front left and right), you may require an additional multimedia speaker or an AV receiver to enjoy the surround sound.

Other than the 5.1-channel surround sound, which is an analogue output, most DVD players carry digital output as coaxial or optical connectivity.

Optical connectivity is useful only if you have an AV receiver capable of receiving and decoding the information. If you don't have the AV receiver capability, don't pay extra to purchase a player with optical connectivity. Moreover, coaxial connectivity does the same job as 'optical.'

The only difference is that coaxial connectivity carries the signal electrically and optical connectivity carries it as light. Coaxial pin is standard on most DVD players.

Additional gadget connectivity. Universal serial bus (USB) is the latest and the most useful connectivity. While USBs used to be found only in PCs, these are now available in DVD players too. The advantage of USB connectivity is that you can play the music and pictures stored in your pen drive. You may even be able to connect your digital camera directly.

Some DVD players also provide DivX playability through USB devices, while others allow you to create MP3 songs from an Audio CD, copy pictures from the disk to pen drive and copy media files.

Ensure that the USB connectivity

Companies selling Blu-ray players

Blu-ray players are available from Sony, Philips, Samsung, LG, Panasonic, Pioneer, Videocon, Sharp, etc. A few models are listed below along with their approximate price:

1. Panasonic DMP-BD35-Rs 25,000
2. Philips BD- Rs 25,000
3. Pioneer BDP-51FD-Rs 45,000
4. Samsung BDP1600-Rs 25,000
5. Sony BDP-S350-Rs 25,000
6. Sony BDP-S350-Rs 30,000
7. Videocon BDP-Rs 22,000

—Sanjeev Jain, PBH Consumer Electronics, Videocon